

IN CONTEXT

The Clementi-Mozart contest

In 1781, Clementi was invited by Emperor Joseph II to play at the imperial court, Vienna. On accepting the invitation, Clementi was unaware that he would be in a contest against a talented local musician, four years his junior, Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart. The contestants were asked to improvise on a theme, then play one of their own works, and also to sight-read a sonata. The duel was declared a draw, the two musicians delighting distinguished guests. Whereas Clementi praised his opponent (“I had never heard anyone play with such spirit”), Mozart (evidently rattled by the Italian’s skill) declared Clementi to be a “charlatan,” a “mere mechanicus.”



EMPEROR JOSEPH II (DETAIL), ANTON VON MARON, 1775

Born in Rome to a humble family in 1752, Muzio Clementi studied music from an early age. By 1766, aged 14, he was an organist at the church of San Lorenzo in Damaso, Rome. Later that year, his keyboard skills were spotted by a wealthy English traveler to Rome, Sir Peter Beckford, who took the talented young musician to his estate in Dorset, England.